

State of the Gaming Industry

The Gaming Industry in India is about to hit a boom. However, the production houses in India are mostly into smaller scale projects on platforms like Web / Mobile / Flash / HTML5. But no need to be disheartened, there are some bigger studios who work on cutting-edge 3D games for PC / PS3 as well. And the rest of the studios have essentially applied the Indian IT industry model of taking outsourced projects to sustain their businesses.

At the same time, The Global Gaming industry is pretty much awaiting a massive change. Social gaming on Facebook has already jumped the shark. Mobile gaming is gaining a stronghold as smartphones become cheaper and more powerful and more and more people are connected via 3G. Today, India and China are seen as the next targets that need to be specifically cracked. While publishers may argue that localized games and content are needed to pierce such a tough market like India with such a diverse demographics, there are designers who say that there is nothing that can be called "Games for India". Games are games. When my mom played Temple Run, she didn't look at the obvious references to Media like Indiana Jones or Uncharted, although she plays it much better than me and enjoys the game fully. The reason being, the game didn't alienate her. So, such a market barrier can be resolved by making the game more accessible.

The position of a Game Designer

So, what is it that a Game Designer is supposed to do? Well, the Game Designer is like the MBA of the Gaming industry. An MBA graduate goes through 36 subjects over 2 years ranging from Mathematics to Economics to Taxation laws. The same holds true for a Game Designer. Apart from knowledge in designing games, a Game Designer is expected to have understanding of Art / Aesthetics, Programming, Project Management, Culture, Languages, Sound Design / Music etc. You will be the *only* person who will have the complete vision of the game in the Team and you will have to work with Programmers, Artists, Project Managers

and even other Designers to bring the game to life. Knowing a thing or two about such topics removes unwanted friction in communication. And since you are a creative person, it is desirable for you to also have a reasonable amount of exposure to varied media such as Movies, Music, Comics, Anime / Manga, TV Shows etc. At the end of the day, making games is a business and you are supposed to make a game that people will be willing to pay for. Games are cultural products and you cannot even accidentally offend people of a certain country because you didn't

which could be produced. Yes, there is no lack of ideas in this industry. You work with teams of extremely talented and creative people and everyone has their own ideas of the game they would like to have made and work on. Normally, peer review and business feasibility are benchmarks for selection of such a game. Once a game enters production, Designers work on a Document called as the GDD or the Game Design Document. A GDD, is sort of like a bible of the entire game. It describes everything about the game right from what the story to the UI to the



know something in your game is considered distasteful in their culture—cultural awareness is necessary.

Your typical work routine

Every Designer has a different style of work and every Game Studio will have a different work-culture and expectations. But, at the end of the day, a major chunk of your work is actually communication. Before the start of any project, Game Designers typically make Documents called as Game Concept or Pitch Documents which are small 1 or 2 page documents describing - say - a new idea for a Shooter game. This is the time when a Game Designer has to be an excellent salesman with remarkable showmanship—enough to convince his peers and the investors alike. Every studio has its due process of selecting Game Concepts

Characters to the Gameplay. The purpose of such a document is to communicate to the team as to how the game will play. So, your Programmer is confused how high the character should jump? The Level Designer is confused how the Boss level will play? The Artist wants to know how big the boss is? All these questions would be normally answered in a GDD. And as teams grow to numbers in hundreds and the production spans for 3-5 years for the bigger AAA games, it becomes crucial to have a one-stop ready reference for such games. Also, it is handy for newcomers in the Team to be able use the GDD to know about the game rather than approach the Game Designer for every little doubt they may have. Point to be noted - apart from tuning the gameplay and brainstorming with your team for ideas, most of your time would be spent in documenting